

FAITH AND THE KINGDOM OF GOD

DAVID LUFF

PART TWO

Continued from the June 2025 issue

In Matthew 13, Jesus described what the progression of the kingdom of heaven looks like from the outside looking in as it develops on the earth during this age. In almost every analogy describing what the kingdom was like, it was depicted as a mixture of good and evil; wheat and tares, leaven (*type of sin*) in a loaf, treasure in a field, good fish and bad fish, the wicked and the just. Is it not the same as the kingdom of heaven being developed in our lives? When we are born again we enter the kingdom of heaven. However, there is a difference in us being in the kingdom of heaven and the kingdom of heaven being in us. When we are born again the Holy Spirit comes to indwell us. Then there is a mixture of the Holy Spirit and our fleshly natures. It is by our submission to the work and leading of the Holy Spirit during our lifetimes that our flesh is put to death and the Holy Spirit gains full control.

The power of the cross to deliver us from the bondage of sin is available for us every day. As is recorded in Romans 6:11, we are exhorted to "*reckon ourselves to be dead unto sin but alive to God in Christ Jesus our Lord.*" If we are to know and experience the power of His resurrection, we must also share in His sufferings (i.e. Philippians 3:10). This means having the same mind and attitude that was in Christ Jesus when he came into the world and as recorded in Philippians 2:5-8, (NKJV), "*Let this mind be in you which was also in Christ Jesus, who, being in the form of God, did not consider it robbery to be equal with God, but made Himself of no reputation, taking the form of a bondservant, and coming in*

the likeness of men. And being found in appearance as a man, He humbled Himself and became obedient to the point of death, even the death of the cross." If we want to experience the resurrection power of Christ in our lives and in the church, we must heed what John the Baptist said, "*He must increase and I must decrease*" (John 3:30, NKJV). It is not so much that we need more of Christ because we have Him in His fullness, but we do need less of self which inhibits the release of His Spirit within us.

When Jesus began His public ministry, He announced, as is recorded in Matthew 4:17 (NKJV), "*Repent, for the kingdom of heaven is at hand.*" Many Christians are looking forward to a future kingdom with an environment as described in Isaiah 9:6-7, Isaiah 11:6-9, Isaiah 35:5-7, Amos 9:13-14, and Micah 4:2-4. As important and wonderful as the environment of the kingdom will be, it cannot come into existence until the people of the kingdom come into being. "*In my opinion whatever we may have to go through now is less than nothing compared with the magnificent future God has planned for us. The whole creation is on tiptoe to see the wonderful sight of the sons of God coming into their own. The world of creation cannot as yet see reality, not because it chooses to be blind, but because in God's purpose it has been so limited—yet it has been given hope. And the hope is that in the end the whole of created life will be rescued from the tyranny of change and decay, and have its share in that magnificent liberty which can only belong to the children of God*" (Romans 8:19-21, J.B. Phillips!)

Immediately after announcing that we were at the threshold of

the kingdom of heaven, He gathered His disciples and preached the iconic Sermon on the Mount as recorded in Matthew 5-7. His opening statement was, *"Blessed are the poor in spirit for theirs is the kingdom of heaven."* His emphasis was not on the environment of the kingdom but rather on the people of the kingdom and the character they would display. He said they would be poor in their own natural spirit, recognizing their own spiritual emptiness and their complete dependence upon God, relying totally by faith on His grace and mercy and the power of the Holy Spirit. The result would be that the kingdom of heaven would be theirs, not just to enter it but to inherit it. He then proceeded to more fully describe in this sermon the principles that would characterize this kingdom and even more importantly the character of the people who would compose the many-membered administrative body of the kingdom of heaven and what the Bible refers to as the overcomers. As one carefully reads this sermon, we see that Jesus not only reaffirms the commandments of the Mosaic law, but he extends its meaning to go beyond the overt acts directed in the law and expands (*fills it up*) to cover thoughts and motives as well (Note in Scofield Bible).

The Sermon on the Mount may very well be the most familiar of all the passages in the New Testament and yet perhaps the least understood and even less obeyed. However, it is apparent that Jesus is very serious that those who would be sons of God will be conformed to the characteristics set forth in this important sermon. As we study this sermon we do not just gain knowledge of the governing principles of the kingdom but, more importantly, we learn what God expects in the way of the behavior of His sons and daughters. He is not waiting to observe this behavior in the millennial kingdom but in the kingdom which is at hand, which is in our midst today. It is arguably the most demanding set of expectations of human behavior ever written. When we sing the song, "It Is Time for the Saints to Take the Kingdom" we are really testifying, "It is time for our behavior to conform to that described in the Sermon on the Mount."

As we read and meditate on Matthew 5-7, we are inclined to have the same response as Jesus' followers when He explained the reality of the communion, *"Many therefore of his disciples, when they had heard this, said, 'This is an hard saying; who can hear it'"* (John 6:60, KJV)? Here again is where we come face-to-face with the fundamental truth of the Gospel for Christians. Jesus used His encounter with the rich young man to reinforce it. The young man, although he believed he was a law-follower, knew something was missing to obtain eternal life. Jesus told him to sell all that he had and follow Him. He went away sorrowful for he had great wealth. Jesus said, *"And again I say to you, it is easier for a camel to go through the eye of a needle than for a rich man to enter the kingdom of God"* (Matthew 19:24, NKJV). His disciples reacted by asking, *"Who then can be saved"* (Matthew 19:25b, NKJV)? What Jesus said next was as much for us today as it was for His disciples then, *"With men this is impossible, but with God all things are possible"* (Matthew 19:26, NKJV).

It is true that we cannot meet the expectations of the Sermon on the Mount on our own, regardless of how strongly we are motivated to do so. Only the Christ-life within us in the person of the Holy Spirit can meet those expectations. However, there is a cooperation with the Holy Spirit that is required from us:

1. First, we must become motivated to "Seek first the kingdom of God and His righteousness" (Matthew 6:33, NKJV). Even this intense desire must be imparted by God into our hearts. However, if we are struggling with having that desire, then we must cry out to God to give it to us. *"Blessed are those who*

hunger and thirst for righteousness for they shall be filled" (Matthew 5:6, NKJV).

2. We must recognize our spiritual deficit and our total dependence on the power of the Holy Spirit to resist and overcome every sin in our lives. *"Blessed are the poor in spirit for theirs is the kingdom of heaven"* (Matthew 5:3, NKJV). We must ask God to give us the faith that persuades us to believe that with God it is possible for us to obey Him.
3. Fall in love with the Word of God and know its power. The Holy Spirit will use it to bolster our faith as we partake of it daily just like the manna from heaven. *"So then faith comes by hearing, and the ear to hear by the word of God"* (Romans 10:17, Jubilee). *"All scripture is given by inspiration of God and is profitable for doctrine, for reproof, for correction, for instruction in righteousness, that the man of God may be perfect, thoroughly furnished unto all good works"* (2 Timothy 3:16-17, NKJV).
4. Maintain an attitude (mindset) of unceasing prayer, acknowledging our continuous and momentary need for a constant connection with the Holy Spirit, calling upon His power at the earliest awareness of temptation to disobey God. It is easier to keep sin out than it is to expel it once it has gained entrance. *"If you do well, will you not be accepted? And if you do not do well, sin lies at the door. And its desire is for you, but you should rule over it"* (Genesis 4:7, NKJV). *"For if you live according to the flesh you will die; but if by the Spirit you put to death the deeds of the body, you will live"* (Romans 8:13, NKJV).
5. Be prepared for suffering of the flesh. The flesh does not give up its desires easily. The sinful nature wants what is contrary to God's will. *"For the flesh lusts against the Spirit, and the Spirit against the flesh; and these are contrary to one another; so that you do not do the things that you wish"* (Galatians 5:17, NKJV). The Scripture says that Jesus learned obedience through the things that He suffered (ref. Hebrews 5:8). He suffered the full extent of obedience to God in the relinquishment of His own will to the will of God. Can we not expect some of the same suffering in laying down our own will to obey God? *"For to this you were called, because Christ also suffered for us, leaving us an example, that you should follow His steps"* (1 Peter 2:21, NKJV). *"Therefore, since Christ suffered for us in the flesh, arm yourselves also with the same mind, for he who has suffered in the flesh has ceased from sin"* (1 Peter 4:1, NKJV).

When we observe what is going on in the world today we see men trying to reconstitute human governments, but their baseless efforts are totally devoid of a belief in Christ and His teachings of the kingdom of God. These efforts will only intensify with each passing year. One after another, each political solution will prove to be a failure because none of them will recognize or accept that sin is at the root of the problem. The only remedy is the kingdom of God, and the kingdom of God cannot come until the people of the kingdom are made ready. It remains that some must give all now, go by the narrow way, and enter by the small gate that leads to life (sonship). Just the thrill of knowing the way of the kingdom is not enough. We must walk it now. Are we willing? *"Blessed is the man who remains steadfast under trial, for when he has stood the test he will receive the crown of life, which God has promised to those who love him"* (James 1:12, ESV). †

LOSS

IS IT A GOOD THING OR A BAD THING?

ANDY SNOKE

Loss. Just the word brings up negative images in the mind. We automatically associate bad things with the word “loss.” It means you had something valuable, but now you have lost it.

I am not making light of loss. We have all, in many ways, suffered genuine loss. The loss of a loved one leaves an irreplaceable hole in one’s heart for the remainder of one’s years.

And yet the truth from heaven often speaks in apparent contradictory terms. Jesus said, *“He who finds his life will lose it, and he who loses his life for My sake will find it”* (Matthew 10:39, NKJV). Just before this verse, Jesus said: *“And he who does not take his cross and follow after Me is not worthy of Me”* (Matthew 10:38). This kind of “loss” results in a great gain.

Jesus said, *“For what shall it profit a man if he gains the whole world, and loses his own soul”* (Mark 8:36, NKJV). Truly, this would be an eternal loss.

When we talk about gains and losses, or, put another way, look at one’s life like an accounting balance sheet with gains (assets) and losses (liabilities), things often move from gains to losses and from losses to gains. Some things we thought were gains were actually losses, and other things were just the opposite.

Losses can often cause people to evaluate their eternal direction. Some people make good directional changes and some do not.

- Lot’s wife could not let go of Sodom and looked back with a longing in her heart and lost her life
- The rich young ruler could not let go of his riches to follow Christ and suffered significant loss.
- King Saul could not let go of his bitterness.
- King Solomon could not let go of his foreign wives.
- Demas could not let go of the world, and suffered loss.

Paul wrote a very personal letter to the Philippians about his gains and losses on his balance sheet, which he had kept track of for over thirty years. Paul was addressing a common problem that had descended on the church at Philippi, an issue that has corrupted many churches today. It is legalism. Paul preached the resurrected Christ, the gospel of grace, and clarified that, *“It is we*

who are the circumcision, we who worship by the Spirit of God, who glory in Christ Jesus, and who put no confidence in the flesh” (Philippians 3:3, NIV).

However, the assemblies were falling back into the traditional Jewish legalistic practices, thinking these would guarantee their salvation. Why is it that mankind struggles so much to accept something that is so very free by engaging in man-designed religious practices and ceremonies that have nothing to do with true salvation. Paul would further explain the steps of salvation to the Romans as follows:

“That if you confess with your mouth the Lord Jesus and believe in your heart that God has raised Him from the dead, you will be saved. For with the heart one believes unto righteousness, and with the mouth confession is made unto salvation” (Romans 10:9-10, NKJV).

To further Paul’s point, the aged apostle listed his natural and spiritual assets and his losses from his life’s balance sheet as follows: *“Though I also might have confidence in the flesh. If anyone else thinks he may have confidence in the flesh, I more so: circumcised the eighth day, of the stock of Israel, of the tribe of Benjamin, a Hebrew of the Hebrews; concerning the law, a Pharisee; concerning zeal, persecuting the church; concerning the righteousness which is in the law, blameless”* (Philippians 3:4-6, NKJV).

It may sound like Paul is bragging, but he is about to make a sharp turn in his discourse. He is about to take all of the above “assets” and turn them into “losses” that bring “heavenly gains.”

*“Yet indeed I also count all things **loss** for the excellence of the knowledge of Christ Jesus my Lord, for whom I have suffered the **loss** of all things, and count them as rubbish, that I may gain Christ”* (Philippians 3:8, NKJV).

Interestingly, the word “loss” used above, which Paul uses, is the word *zemian* in Greek. It is used only two other times in the New Testament (Acts 27:10,21). It is in reference to the ship experience that Paul had in a storm with a cargo of human souls and valuables. All valuables were thrown overboard to lighten and save the ship. They were counted as “zemian” and as “loss” to save the souls on board from drowning. How impactful. That

which seems so valuable in life could potentially stand in the way of heaven.

Paul said that he suffered the loss of all things and counted all of these things that were at one time so important to him, i.e., his Judaistic zeal, his ancestry and his education, as rubbish. The Greek word for “rubbish” means either “bodily excrement,” or “food fit only for dogs.” Now, when I say food only fit for dogs, in the days of Paul, they did not have fancy tins of gourmet dog food prepared for dogs like we do today! Humans, in Paul’s day, would love to eat like our pets do today.

Paul lost all he once was and became all Christ wanted him to be. His losses became great gains. His one-time gains became losses. His losses for Christ were great gains. The balance sheet was changing in Paul’s favor.

Jesus talked about these eternal treasures when he said: *“Do not lay up for yourselves treasures on earth, where moth and rust destroy and where thieves break in and steal; but lay up for yourselves treasures in heaven, where neither moth nor rust destroys and where thieves do not break in and steal. For where your treasure is, there your heart will be also”* (Matthew 6:19-21, NKJV).

Paul continues to explain to the Philippians what he is reaching out to gain: *“And be found in Him, not having my own righteousness, which is from the law, but that which is through faith in Christ, the righteousness which is from God by faith; that I may know Him and the power of His resurrection, and the fellowship of His sufferings, being conformed to His death, if, by any means, I may attain to the resurrection from the dead”* (Philippians 3:9-11, NKJV).

“Not that I have already attained, or am already perfected; but I press on, that I may lay hold of that for which Christ Jesus has also laid hold of me. Brethren, I do not count myself to have apprehended; but one thing I do, forgetting those things which are behind and reaching forward to those things which are ahead, I press toward the goal for the prize of the upward call of God in Christ Jesus” (Philippians 3:12-14, NKJV).

Peter, one of the more outspoken of the twelve, was direct enough to remind the Lord that they had given up everything to follow Him. He asked “Therefore, what shall we have?”

Jesus replied: *“Then Peter answered and said to Him, ‘See, we have left all and followed You. Therefore what shall we have?’ So Jesus said to them, ‘Assuredly I say to you, that in the regeneration, when the Son of Man sits on the throne of His glory, you who have followed Me will also sit on twelve thrones, judging the twelve tribes of Israel. And everyone who has left houses or brothers or sisters or father or mother or wife or children or lands, for My name’s sake, shall receive a hundredfold, and inherit eternal life”* (Matthew 19:27-29, NKJV).

We are blessed that when Jesus answered, He said, *“And EVERYONE who has left houses or brothers or sisters or father or mother or wife or children or lands, for My name’s sake, shall receive a hundredfold, and inherit eternal life.”* That includes not just Peter, but you and me also.

Try to avoid being confused by this verse from a North American point of view and wonder why you would have to leave such things as father and mother for His name’s sake. Believe me, when I say that we have met very precious souls, young ladies who have come to Christ in foreign lands, who have been beaten by their fathers and kicked to the streets for leaving the dark pagan religion of their families. They chose to leave their homes, and their families for Christ, and for their safety. Persecution is happening today in the church in foreign lands.

So, is loss a good thing, or a bad thing? It can be both. 

GLOBAL MISSIONS INC.

Global Missions Inc. was founded in 1944, as a Christian mission to promote and encourage the preaching of the gospel to every creature.

Global Missions reaches into many countries in Africa, India, the Caribbean, the United States of America, South America and the Philippines. These local churches are established on the foundational truths revealed in God’s word and through His unfolding revelation. Local churches are governed by local residents who are referred to as elders.

Global Missions is a nondenominational Christian church.

Headquarters:
802 Airport Road
North Battleford, SK S9A 2Z3 Canada

Mailing Address:
P.O. Box 934
North Battleford, SK S9A 2Z3 Canada

Telephone:
(306) 445-2733

Email:
info@globalmissionsinc.org

Online:
www.globalmissionsinc.org

Traveling Ministry Contact List:
www.globalmissionsinc.org/about

SHARON

The Sharon Star is a monthly publication and mailed as a free-will offering plan. The articles within are intended for inspiration and information to those who are interested in the unfolding revelation of the Word of God.

Published by:
Global Missions Inc. in North Battleford, Saskatchewan, Canada.

The Sharon Star is found online at:
www.globalmissionsinc.org/sharon-star

Publications Mail Agreement 40012206

Subscribe by mail or online.